

Carolina Raptor Center Seeks \$80,000 To Feather A New Nest

By DIANNE WHITACRE

Staff Writer

The Carolina Raptor Center is \$80,000 away from building an environmental education center in Latta Plantation Park.

Its board plans to break ground before the end of the year on a 5,800-square-foot building, just west of the wooded trails where American bald eagles, red-tailed hawks and barred owls are on display. But plans hinge on finding \$80,000 to get the project under way.

"We'll be able to put on educational programs there rather than in our parking lot," said Jim Arthur, a board member of the nonprofit organization that cares for injured birds of prey. The Raptor Center is now headquartered in two trailers in Latta Plantation — one its raptor hospital and the other an office.

The largest donation has come from Fred and Edna Moretti — a \$100,000 pledge contingent on the center's finding the money elsewhere to begin construction this year. "We had planned to have a building by 1993 and then suddenly this \$100,000 comes up," Arthur said.

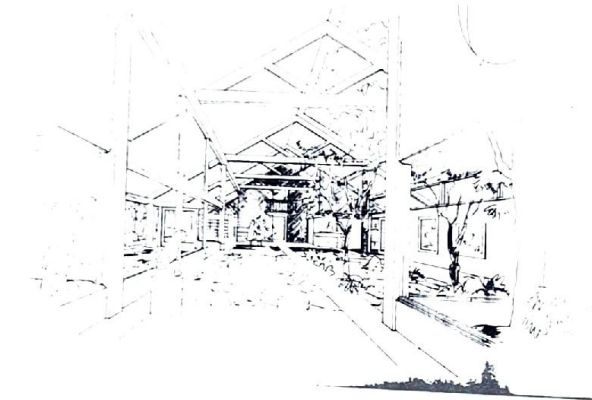
Pat Marcum, executive director, is determined that \$100,000 won't slip away. "We will break ground this year," she said. "This will be a wonderful environmental educational center."

The raptor center will be similar to the three aquariums that the State of North Carolina operates at Fort Fisher, Atlantic Beach and Manteo, only it will educate the public about birds rather than fish, Arthur said.

Momentum is building:

- The Mecklenburg Board of County Commissioners has extended the raptor center's \$1-a-year lease on the 57 acres it uses in Latta Plantation Park. It will expire in 2085.

- Commissioners told the county Park and Recreation Department to find \$40,000 in its budget to build the educational center, if the raptor center raises the \$80,000 needed to break



Fred and Edna Moretti will donate \$100,000 to the raptor center, if construction of the new center begins in 1990. Edna Moretti is a volunteer at the center.

ground.

- Architect Herbert Lawton has prepared free preliminary drawings for the center. Lawton designed the Jimmy Carter Library in Atlanta.

- Grant proposals have been made to about a dozen Charlotte-area foundations and corporations.

Marcum said the raptor center is not making a special effort to ask its members and regular contributors to donate money because the board is afraid that would dry up donations for the annual \$180,000 operating budget.

"We have to still keep paying the electrical bill," she said.

The \$291,000 environmental education center will have an exhibit hall, auditorium, offices, gift shop, an aviary for the American kestrel and another for the eastern screech owl. An indoor exhibit will give visitors an underground look at burrowing owls. An outdoor viewing area will have a small pond, feeders and plants chosen to attract birds and other wildlife.

The raptor center will delay building the auditorium at a savings of \$70,000 if the fund-raising is slower than expected, Arthur said.

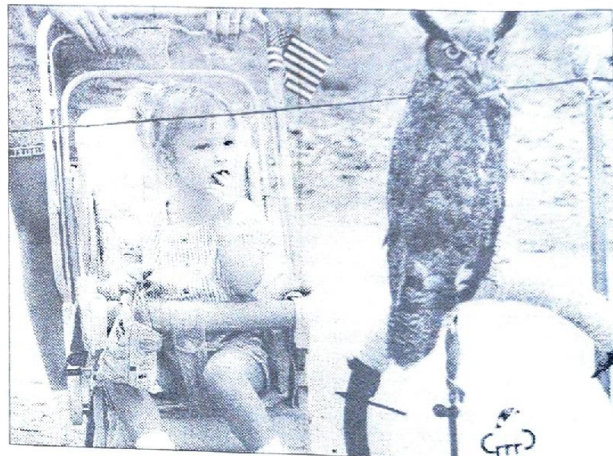
Within the next 10 years, the raptor center wants to move its hospital into a building complete with surgical and X-ray equipment for the 300 to 400 injured birds of prey it treats each year. When that move is made, the center will become more involved in research and breeding endangered species.

Deborah Sue Griffin started the Carolina Raptor Center 10 years ago when she volunteered to raise an orphaned great horned owl.

"I did everything wrong," she said. "That bird grew up so imprinted on (accustomed to) humans it never could be released."

The owl lived in Griffin's apartment and went on a vacation with her parents.

One owl led to another, and another, and eventually she convinced UNC Charlotte, where she

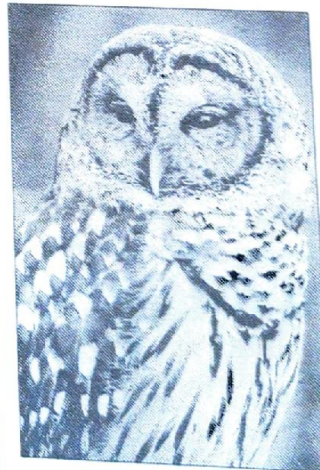


File Photo

Birds of prey on exhibit at the Carolina Raptor Center, like this great horned owl, have recovered from the injuries that brought them there, but are unable to live in the wild.

was a student, to allow her to care for injured and orphaned birds of prey in a basement room of the biology building.

In 1984, the Carolina Raptor Center moved to Latta Plantation Park, drawing 15,000 visitors and giving 350 educational programs a year. The enlarged raptor center will offer exhibits and programs to teach the public about sharing their world with owls, eagles, hawks and vultures.



File Photo

Interested

To make a tax-deductible donation, send a check to the Carolina Raptor Center, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297. The center is in Latta Plantation Park, on Sample Road, off Beatties Ford Road. Hours are noon to 5 p.m., Wednesday through Sunday.

This barred owl is a resident of the Carolina Raptor Center.